



THE HISTORY PORTAL | HISTORY DEPARTMENT

EDITION 2026.1

WHY DID MEDIEVAL MEDICINE CHANGE SO LITTLE — AND WHAT FINALLY BROKE THE DEADLOCK?

*Paper 1: Medicine Through Time with the Western
Front - Medieval*

Scholar: _____

Class: _____

Edexcel Specification: c1250–c1500

- **1. Causes of disease:** Supernatural/religious explanations, Astrology, Four Humours, and Miasma.
- **2. Prevention and treatment:** Religious actions, bloodletting, purging, purifying air.
- **3. Medical care:** The role of physicians, apothecaries, barber surgeons, and hospitals.
- **4. Case Study: The Black Death (1348):** Beliefs about its causes, treatments, and prevention.

PROGRESS & ASSESSMENT TRACKER

TARGET GRADE: _____

Grade	9-1 GCSE Grading Scale		
Lesson / Assessment Title	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: KT1.1: What did Medieval people believe caused illness?			
L2: KT1.2: How did Medieval people try to prevent and treat disease?			
L3: KT1.3: How did people respond to the Black Death?			
Final Unit Grade:			

L1: KT1.1: What did Medieval people believe caused illness?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how supernatural and religious factors influenced beliefs about the cause of illness.
- ☐ Analyse the rational, natural theories of disease used in medieval England.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What does the term 'public health' refer to?

Name one ancient civilization that heavily influenced medieval medicine.

Which Greek physician originally created the Theory of the Four Humours?

Which Roman physician developed the Theory of Opposites?

What are the four humours?

What was 'miasma'?

How did the medieval Church explain the cause of disease?

Why did the medieval Church promote the ideas of Galen?

Explain how astrology was used in medieval medicine.

What was the 'urine chart' used for in medieval diagnosis?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?

Four Humours | Theory of Opposites | Miasma | Astrology | Hippocrates | Galen

Q1. Explain how supernatural and religious beliefs were used to explain the causes of disease in medieval England.

Q2. The Theory of the Four Humours and Galenic Medicine

GCSE TWO-SIDED ARGUMENT

GCSE Analytical Assessment: Evaluate the logical strengths and scientific limitations of Galenic humoral medicine in the Middle Ages.

▲ Logical & Natural Rationale (Rationality) • Provided a rational, natural explanation for illness based on physical bodily fluids (blood, phlegm, yellow bile, black bile) rather than blaming demons or witchcraft. • Galen's Theory of Opposites gave physicians a systematic framework for prescribing clinical treatments (e.g. treating a cold phlegmatic fever with hot, dry pepper). • Encouraged careful observation of bodily symptoms, diet, and clinical pulse taking. Starter: "On the one hand, the Theory of the Four Humours was considered a rational medical framework because..."	■ Doctrinal Stagnation & Flaws • The four humours were factually non-existent; treatments based on balancing them (bleeding, purging, vomiting) severely weakened sick patients and frequently proved fatal. • The Catholic Church adopted Galen as absolute dogma because his writings argued the body was designed by a single Creator, making criticism of Galen an act of heresy. • The Church strictly banned human dissection, freezing anatomical knowledge in classical antiquity and preventing doctors from discovering real bodily organs. Counter: "However, Galenic humoral medicine severely hindered medical progress because..."
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GCSE Paragraph Builder: Write a balanced GCSE exam paragraph evaluating why Galenic medicine dominated the medieval period despite having fatal medical flaws.

Connectives: Although the Four Humours offered a naturalistic explanation... • However, its factual inaccuracies meant that... • Furthermore, because the Church enforced it as religious dogma... • Consequently...

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q3)

Why did the Church promote the work of the ancient Roman doctor Galen?

☐ A. Because Galen proved that God sent diseases as a punishment.

- ☐ B. Because Galen's theory of a perfectly designed body fit Christian creation theology.
- ☐ C. Because Galen was a devout Christian.
- ☐ D. Because he was the personal physician to the Pope.

Q4. Evaluate the significance of the Church in holding back medical progress in the Middle Ages.

Q5. Using the Claudius Galen Key Individual card, explain why Galen made anatomical errors, and why these errors remained unchallenged throughout the Middle Ages.

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: Which factor was the most powerful barrier to medieval medical progress: the absolute authority of the Christian Church, or the logical appeal of the Theory of the Four Humours?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (e.g., Church control of universities/libraries, or how symptoms like sneezing phlegm seemed to prove the humours existed).

Your Notes:

16-MARK ESSAY PLANNING MATRIX (2×2 GRID)

Edexcel Paper 1 • Section B (Q5/Q6)

Question: 'The Church was the main reason why there was little change in ideas about the cause of disease in the period c1250–c1500.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

Stimulus: The role of the Church • Galen

✓ Factors Supporting Statement (Agree)

- The Catholic Church held an absolute monopoly over education, universities, and the copying of medical manuscripts, actively enforcing Galen's anatomical and humoral writings as infallible Christian dogma.
- Illness was taught to be sent directly by God as divine punishment for sin or a test of faith, meaning that seeking natural scientific causes or questioning classical authority was condemned as sinful heresy.

⇌ Counter-Factors / Other Factors (Disagree)

- The logical internal coherence of Hippocrates' Theory of the Four Humours and Galen's Theory of Opposites (treatments seemed to match observable symptoms like sweating during fever or sneezing phlegm).
- A total lack of scientific instruments and technology: without microscopes, it was physically impossible for medieval people to discover microscopic bacteria, making miasma and humours the only rational explanations.

Level 4 Judgment Criteria: Weigh the relative importance: Was the Catholic Church's theological authority the active institutional cause of stagnation, or was the absence of scientific technology and alternative empirical proof the fundamental limiting factor?

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. Describe two features of Galen's Theory of Opposites.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q8. Explain one way in which ideas about the cause of disease in the medieval period (c1250–c1500) were similar to ideas about the cause of disease in the Renaissance period (c1500–c1700).

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q9. Explain why the Church had such a significant influence on medieval medicine in the period c1250–c1500.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

[illegible]

Q10. Explain why there was so little change in ideas about the cause of disease in the years c.1250-c.1500.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- The Church
- Galen

You must also use information of your own.

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[illegible]

General Notes

[illegible]

The Intellectual Triad: Hippocrates, Galen & The Catholic Church

Core Historical Context: In medieval Europe, medical authority did not rest upon scientific experiments or clinical trials. Instead, it was anchored to an unshakeable intellectual triad: Ancient Greek philosophy, Imperial Roman anatomy, and Christian theology. Use this visual revision guide to revise all medieval beliefs about disease before answering the Edexcel exam questions opposite.

HIGH-YIELD TERMINOLOGY: Four Humours Theory of Opposites Clinical Observation Teleology Monastic Scriptoria
Roger Bacon (1277) Heresy Miasma Uroscopy (Matula) Zodiac Man Lazar House Regimen Sanitatis

The Catholic Church (c. 500 – 1500 AD)

Monopoly on Truth

Institutional Control: Monastic Scriptoria, Universities & Religious Dogma

Why did the Church embrace Galen?

Galen argued every organ had a purposeful divine design created by a single Creator (teleology). This aligned perfectly with Genesis, so the Church declared his writings infallible sacred truth.

How was medical dogma enforced?

Monks controlled manuscript copying; universities taught only Galen and Hippocrates. Questioning dogma was heresy; Roger Bacon was imprisoned in 1277 for advocating experimental science.

1. Ancient Roots to Roman Doctrine

Galen adopted Hippocrates' Four Humours, developed the Theory of Opposites, and systematized Greek medicine into 350+ Latin treatises.

2. Theological Sanctification

Monastic scriptoria translated and hand-copied Galen; the Church declared his teleological writings infallible doctrine alongside scripture.

3. The 1,400-Year Stagnation

With university curricula fixed on Galen and dissent punished as heresy, medical inquiry halted completely until the Renaissance.



Hippocrates of Kos

c. 460 – c. 370 BC • **Ancient Greek Roots**
Clinical Observation & The Four Humours

The Four Humours Theory:

Blood (Spring/Air/Hot & Wet), Phlegm (Winter/Water/Cold & Wet), Yellow Bile (Summer/Fire/Hot & Dry), Black Bile (Autumn/Earth/Cold & Dry). Sickness was an internal humoral imbalance.

The Clinical Method & Regimen Sanitatis:

Revolutionary rejection of spirits and demons. Promoted bedside observation (pulse, symptoms) and balanced lifestyle (diet, rest, exercise) in the Regimen Sanitatis.



Claudius Galenus (Galen)

AD 129 – c. 216 • **Roman Imperial Synthesis**
Theory of Opposites & Teleological Anatomy

The Theory of Opposites:

Expanded humoral balance by treating symptoms with their contrary (e.g. cold, wet phlegm treated with hot, dry pepper; excess hot blood treated with cold cucumber or bloodletting).

Anatomical Errors & 1,300-Year Dogma:

Dissected pigs and Barbary apes due to Roman taboos, claiming the human liver had 5 lobes and jaw had 2 bones. His errors were frozen as sacred truth for 1,300 years.

MEDIEVAL EXPLANATIONS FOR DISEASE: SUPERNATURAL & ENVIRONMENTAL

God's Wrath, Sin & Leprosy **Supernatural**

The Church taught that illness was a punishment from God for sins or a test of faith. Lepers were cast out into Lazar houses, forced to ring bells and wear cloaks. Prayer, fasting, pilgrimages, and flagellation were seen as genuine cures.

Astrology & The 1345 **Astrological** Alignment

Physicians consulted Almanacs and star charts to check planetary alignments. In 1345, an unusual conjunction of Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn was blamed for the Black Death. Star alignments were believed to directly corrupt the humours.

Miasma & Pestilential Air **Environmental**

Bad air from rotting waste, swamps, and filth was believed to poison the body. People burned incense, carried pomanders or sweet herbs, and avoided foul-smelling areas to protect their humoral balance.

THE PHYSICIAN'S DIAGNOSTIC TOOLKIT & ACADEMIC TRAINING

Uroscopy (The Urine Chart)

The primary diagnostic tool. Physicians examined urine in a glass matula, checking colour, density, smell, and even taste against a 20-shade chart. White/watery urine indicated excess phlegm; deep red indicated excess blood. Cathedral priories hired full-time urine examiners.

The Zodiac Man (Homo Signorum)

Included in every physician's pocket Vademecum handbook. Illustrated how the 12 star signs governed different bodily organs (e.g. Aries ruled the head; Pisces the feet). Doctors were strictly forbidden to bleed or operate when the Moon was in a body part's governing sign.

University Dissection Ritual

Medical training at Oxford, Paris, and Bologna was based on book learning, not practical treatment. During rare dissections, the professor (Lector) sat in a high chair reading Galen, while an assistant cut. If the body contradicted Galen, the corpse was dismissed as malformed.

SYNOPTIC CROSS-ERA LINKS: MEDIEVAL VS. RENAISSANCE (C.1500–C.1700)

Continuity: Miasma & Humours in the Renaissance

Key
Similarity

Miasma remained the leading explanation for epidemics like the Great Plague (1665). Ordinary people still used bloodletting, purging, and herbal remedies to balance humours throughout the 16th and 17th centuries.

Change: Challenging Galen (Vesalius & Harvey)

Anatomical
Shift

Vesalius (1543) proved Galen made human errors (e.g. human lower jaw is 1 bone, not 2). William Harvey (1628) proved blood circulates, disproving Galen's idea that the liver constantly manufactured new blood.

Change: Thomas Sydenham (1676)

Diagnostic
Shift

Known as the "English Hippocrates", Sydenham moved medicine away from individual humoral imbalance toward diagnosing diseases as distinct, external species with fixed symptom patterns.

3 KEY CAUSAL FACTORS: WHY IDEAS ABOUT CAUSE REMAINED STAGNANT (C.1250–C.1500)

Factor 1:

The Catholic Church's monopoly on education, universities, and hand-copied manuscripts prevented new ideas.

Factor 2:

Galen's teleological theory of purposeful design aligned with Christian creation, making his texts sacred and unchallengeable.

Factor 3:

Lack of alternative scientific explanations or technology (no microscopes, no printing press) reinforced reliance on ancient tradition.

Exam Practice: Question 3 (Similarity or Difference) & Question 4 (Explain Why)

Edexcel GCSE (9–1) Paper 1 • Question 3

[4 Marks]

Explain one way in which ideas about the causes of illness in the Medieval period (c.1250–c.1500) were similar to ideas about the causes of illness in the Renaissance period (c.1500–c.1700).

Strategy: Timing: 5 mins • Structure: 1 developed comparative PEEL paragraph. Focus on ONE valid similarity with specific knowledge from both eras. (e.g. Continued widespread belief in miasma / bad air as a cause of epidemics, or the enduring reliance on humoural imbalance). Do NOT write both similarity and difference!

Edexcel GCSE (9–1) Paper 1 • Question 4

[12 Marks]

Explain why there was so little change in medical ideas about the causes of disease between c.1250 and c.1500.

STIMULUS TRACKING CHECKLIST:

☐ The Catholic Church

☐ Galen

☐ Own Knowledge (P3)

(You must also use information of your own.) [12 marks]

Strategy: Timing: 18 mins • Structure: 3 fully developed PEEL paragraphs (P1: Church, P2: Galen, P3: Own Knowledge)

EDEXCEL PAPER 1 ASSESSMENT • MARKING CRITERIA

Q3: / 4

Q4: / 12

Total: / 16

Q4 L1 (1–3 m):
Generalised statements; simple points with limited knowledge.

Q4 L2 (4–6 m):
Descriptive explanation of 1–2 factors with basic links to question.

Q4 L3 (7–9 m):
Explains 2 factors with accurate detail and clear causal reasoning.

Q4 L4 (10–12 m):
Analytical explanation of 3 factors (stimuli + own); sustained causal focus.

Teacher Feedback: _____

L2: KT1.2: How did Medieval people try to prevent and treat disease?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the connection between medieval beliefs about disease and their approaches to treatment and prevention.
- ☐ Evaluate the roles, training, and accessibility of different medical healers in medieval society.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

Which Roman physician developed the Theory of Opposites?

How did the medieval Church explain the cause of disease?

What was 'miasma'?

What are the four humours?

Explain how astrology was used in medieval medicine.

What was the 'urine chart' used for in medieval diagnosis?

What does the term 'public health' refer to?

Name one ancient civilization that heavily influenced medieval medicine.

Under the Theory of Opposites, how would a fever (hot/dry) be treated?

Which Greek physician originally created the Theory of the Four Humours?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Phlebotomy | Purging | Regimen Sanitatis | Theriaca | Apothecary | Barber Surgeon

Q1. Identify one supernatural method used to prevent disease.

Q2. Medieval Hospitals: Care versus Cure

GCSE TWO-SIDED ARGUMENT

GCSE Analytical Assessment: Evaluate the compassionate care provided by medieval hospitals against their total lack of medical cures.

▲ Compassionate Care & Hospitality - Hundreds of hospitals established by religious orders (over 700 in England by 1500, e.g. St Bartholomew's in London founded 1123). - Provided clean beds, warmth, nutritious food, clean water, and peaceful shelter for the destitute, elderly, and travelers. - Monks and nuns offered compassionate spiritual comfort, palliative nursing, and dignity to the dying. <i>Starter: "On the one hand, medieval hospitals provided essential humanitarian care because..."</i>	■ Total Lack of Medical Cure - Hospitals provided care, NOT cure; doctors and surgeons were rarely employed, and surgical operations were forbidden. - Infectious, contagious patients and pregnant women were strictly turned away to prevent contaminating the wards. - Primary focus was on saving the soul through daily mass, prayer, and confession, leaving physical disease untreated. <i>Counter: "However, medieval hospitals were completely ineffective at curing disease because..."</i>
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GCSE Paragraph Builder: Write a balanced GCSE exam paragraph evaluating the statement: "Medieval hospitals were places of spiritual hospitality rather than medical treatment."

Connectives: Although hospitals provided vital shelter and basic nursing... • However, in terms of clinical medicine... • Because infectious diseases were excluded... • Ultimately...

Q3. Explain how the Theory of Opposites was used in treatments.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q4)

What was the main difference between an apothecary and a physician?

- ☐ A. Physicians performed surgery, apothecaries diagnosed illness.
- ☐ B. Apothecaries mixed herbal remedies based on experience, while physicians diagnosed using astrology and ancient books.
- ☐ C. Apothecaries were trained at university, physicians were not.
- ☐ D. Physicians were always monks, apothecaries were always women.

Q5. To what extent were medieval treatments dangerous for patients?

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: If you were a medieval peasant, who would you trust more to care for your family: an expensive university-trained physician who diagnosed using urine and star charts, or a female family member treating you in the home with herbal remedies?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence from the sources (such as the Paston family letters showing deep distrust of professional physicians, or the fact that women treated families for free with garden herbs like marigolds and clover).

Your Notes:

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. Describe two features of the role of the medieval apothecary.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q8. Explain why bleeding and purging were such common treatments in the medieval period (c1250-c1500).

[12 marks • 15 mins]

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Q9. Explain why there was little change in the care provided by hospitals in the period c.1250-c.1500.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- Monks and nuns
- infectious diseases

You must also use information of your own.

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General Notes

[illegible]

L3: KT1.3: How did people respond to the Black Death?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the religious and supernatural responses to the Black Death.
- ☐ Analyse the rational and governmental methods used to prevent and treat the plague.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

What was the purpose of 'bleeding' (phlebotomy) in medieval medicine?

What was the role of a medieval apothecary?

How did medieval hospitals differ from modern ones?

What was 'purging'?

What was the role of a medieval barber surgeon?

What was the 'Regimen Sanitatis'?

Which Roman physician developed the Theory of Opposites?

What was 'miasma'?

How did the medieval Church explain the cause of disease?

What are the four humours?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Buboes Flagellants Quarantine Miasma Pestilence Compulsory Isolation	
Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society

Q1. Identify the true cause of the Black Death.

Q2. Describe two ways people tried to prevent the Black Death.

Q3. Explain why the government's response to the Black Death failed.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK (Q4)

Why were the government's orders to clean the streets completely ineffective at stopping the Black Death?

- ☐ A. Because the peasants refused to obey the King's laws.
- ☐ B. Because the disease was actually a punishment from God.
- ☐ C. Because they were trying to remove bad smells (miasma), but ignored the rats and fleas that actually spread the disease.
- ☐ D. Because the dirt on the streets was actually killing the germs.

Q5. Evaluate the impact of the Black Death on medieval society.

Pair & Share Activity

Q6. Prompt: Was the medieval response to the Black Death dominated more by desperate spiritual panic or by logical, rational attempts at disease prevention based on the scientific ideas of the time?

Think: Jot down your choice and one piece of evidence (e.g., the public whipping of the flagellants vs. mayors ordering rakers to clear dung and waste from the streets to stop bad air).

Your Notes:

16-MARK ESSAY PLANNING MATRIX (2×2 GRID)

Edexcel Paper 1 • Section B (Q5/Q6)

Question: 'The main reason why medical care and treatment was ineffective during the medieval period (c1250–c1500) was because medical knowledge was based on Galen's ideas.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

Stimulus: The Four Humours • The Black Death

✓ Factors Supporting Statement (Agree)

- Galen's flawed humoural physiology and Theory of Opposites led directly to physically harmful clinical treatments like severe bloodletting (phlebotomy) and purging, which severely weakened infected patients.
- Medical education strictly required physicians to memorise Galen's texts rather than conduct practical research; treatments targeted humoural symptoms (e.g. cold cucumbers for fever) rather than underlying infections.

⇌ Counter-Factors / Other Factors (Disagree)

- Pervasive supernatural and religious beliefs during crises like the Black Death (1348), where populations relied on public flagellation, prayer, and pilgrimages that actively accelerated contagion rather than containing it.
- Monastic hospitals (over 1,100 in England by 1500) were run by monks and nuns to provide hospitality and spiritual care for the soul rather than physical medical cures, strictly excluding infectious victims.

Level 4 Judgment Criteria: Weigh the relative importance: Did Galen's flawed anatomical models cause treatment failures, or did religious doctrine prioritizing spiritual salvation over biological cure prevent effective healthcare?

GCSE Exam Practice

Q7. Describe two features of how medieval people tried to prevent the spread of the Black Death.

[4 marks • 5 mins]

Q8. Explain why the Black Death spread so rapidly in Britain in 1348.

[12 marks • 15 mins]

[illegible]

[illegible]

Q9. 'The main reason why medical care and treatment was ineffective during the medieval period (c1250-c1500) was because medical knowledge was based on Galen's ideas.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

[20 marks • 25 mins]

You may use the following in your answer:

- The Four Humours
- The Black Death

You must also use information of your own.

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

General Notes

[illegible]

End of Unit Reflection & Pupil Voice

Unit: Paper 1: Medicine Through Time

Instructions: Now that you have completed your final assessment, take 10 minutes to reflect on your learning across this entire unit. Be honest—this is your chance to use your **Pupil Voice** to help your teacher plan future lessons.

1. What Went Well (WWW)

What topic or skill did you find most engaging or easiest to understand in this unit?

2. Even Better If (EBI)

What did you find most challenging? Are there any concepts you are still confused about?

3. Effort & Target Setting

Circle your effort level for this unit: **1 (Low)** **2** **3** **4** **5 (Excellent)**

What is one specific target you want to set for yourself in the next unit?

Teacher Feedback & Coaching

(To be completed during live marking / feedback lessons)

Factors Overview: Medieval

Edexcel focuses heavily on the factors that drove medical progress (or held it back). For each factor below, write one specific historical example from this period that either helped or hindered medical progress.

Factor	Specific Historical Example & Impact
Individuals	
The Church & Religion	
Government & Wealth	
Science & Technology	
Attitudes in Society	
War	